

PARAMANAND GIRI, *65*
Trustee
Head of the Akhand Ashram in Haridwar. Has authored over 150 books on Vedanta



MAHANT DINENDRA DAS, *63*
Full-time trustee
Principal representative of the Nirmohi Akhara, he was inducted into the Trust in compliance with the Supreme Court's direction

KRISHNA MOHAN, *68; Trustee*



Retired Indian Forest Service officer and RSS veteran. Was inducted into the Trust after the demise of founding trustee Kameshwar Chaupal

EX-OFFICIO TRUSTEES
Senior bureaucrats **PRASHANT LOKHANDE** (Centre's representative) and **SANJAY PRASAD** (representing Uttar Pradesh) serve on the Trust. So does Ayodhya district magistrate (DM) **SHASHANK TRIPATHI**, by virtue of his position

***Note:** Following the SC verdict in favour of the construction of the Ram temple in 2019, the Centre constituted the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust on February 5, 2020. The trust comprises 15 members. One post lies vacant as of now*

called it a "Rs 5,000 crore scam", questioning the opacity over the vast sums collected for the temple since the 1990s. With the UP assembly polls a mere seven months away, managing the fallout has become a high-stakes game for the BJP. For it to pass muster before a sceptical public, the culprits had to be brought to justice. Equally crucially, as a BJP insider put it, "there had to be a thorough cleansing of the way the temple was being administered."

Among the first to condemn the theft was Nripendra Misra, chairperson of the SRJTKT's temple construction committee that had overseen the building of the Ram Mandir. Talking to INDIA TODAY TV, Misra, a former principal secretary to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, termed the alleged loot of donations made in the name of Lord Ram "very, very sad indeed". "It has eroded the faith of the devotees," he said. Calling for a revamp of the temple management, he added, "There are two aspects to the investigation—'criminal' and 'future improvement'. Only when both these aspects are addressed will we be able to regain the trust of the devotees."

The Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP), which for decades had spearheaded the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, was quick to not only condemn the theft but also distance itself from the incident. Though Rai continues to be its international vice president, VHP president Alok Kumar made it clear that "it is not the job of the VHP in any part of the country to construct temples or to run them. The Trust would run them and what happens in the Trust would be the responsibility of the Trust. What has happened in Ayodhya is very disgraceful and shameful. All of us, all the Hindus in the world, particularly those who donated funds, and the *kar sevak*s and their families, are deeply hurt. Whosoever is guilty should be tried and punished."



"The BJP has betrayed Lord Ram. The first name of *maryada* (righteousness) is Lord Ram...its second name is the Constitution; the BJP has betrayed both. They have no *dharam* (faith) or *sharam* (shame)"

—AKHILESH YADAV
President, Samajwadi Party

Cash Course

How did the embezzlement happen? People familiar with the counting process corroborate the SIT's reconstruction: it was not a single heist, but a whole system of loosely enacted protocol meant to leak systematically. Besides 10 donation counters that hand out computerised receipts, the temple complex has a total of 35-40 *hundi*s (donation boxes), six near the sanctum sanctorum and others strewn around sub-temples and public collection points. Average daily collections can go up to Rs 13 lakh, peaking to Rs 50 lakh on weekends and big days on the religious calendar. In FY25, the Trust declared Rs 153 crore as direct contribution from devotees out of the total annual income of Rs 327 crore.

In theory, a strict SOP is meant to fully sanitise the journey of each *hundi*. They are required to be opened in the presence of at least four authorised individuals, with proper records of each instance. What the SIT describes is closer to laissez faire, a process not much encumbered by oversight—beginning from unauthorised custodians handling the keys, bypassing